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Peacebuilding made Simple?

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Conflict Assessment and Peacebuilding Planning: Toward a Participatory Approach to Human Security. By Lisa Schirch. Boulder and London, Kumarian, 2013. 229 pp., \$22 paperback (ISBN: 978-1-56549-579-1).

Lisa Schirch's ambitious handbook tackles complex challenges of contemporary peacebuilding in an accessible format. By providing "easy-to-use conceptual frameworks for seeing and learning about the complex, dynamic conflict system" (p. 1), Schirch's volume sets out to respond to problems of "untested assumptions and lack of assessment" (p. 1), and of coordination and harmonisation among diverse peacebuilding actors, by contributing "more coherent terminology and foundational concepts linking academic sources and practitioner tools" (p2). All this and more is wrestled with through a "whole of society" approach that engages both government and civil society (p. 27) and can be applied at multiple scales from local urban or remote communities to policymaking elites at national and global levels (p. 2).

To advance this ambitious agenda, Schirch advocates for a broad systems approach that attends to the interplay of conflict drivers and 'mitigators' through self-reflexive conflict assessment research, design and planning based in theories of change, and a welcome focus on monitoring and evaluation. The handbook is also borne of recent debates and preoccupations in the peacebuilding field, as reflected in a focus on human security as well as advocacy for local participation and attention to questions of culture and identity.

There is much of value in this clearly-organised and accessibly-written handbook, especially for those who are looking for an accessible way to navigate the complicated and confusing world of peacebuilding and conflict prevention and resolution. The simple cyclical model (p. 2), and the adoption of familiar and everyday language for guiding research

(including use of Where, Who, Why, What, How and When questions) provides a means for cutting through often murky and baffling practical, political and logistical challenges, potentially helping to advance more reflective and analytically informed peacebuilding practice in situations where peacebuilders too often simply ‘muddle through’ with a vague sense of the value and importance of their efforts. (As Schirch notes, “[e]fforts to achieve peace are often driven by untested assumptions, convenience, or some other motive...” [p. 174]).

However, this reader was also left with persistent doubts about whether the approach Schirch advocates is adequate to the challenges of contemporary peacebuilding. No doubt simplicity is a virtue for establishing an accessible framework, but perhaps the key problem with Schirch’s volume is that it remains rather too simple – and too familiar – for dealing with what is complex and different. Advice on stakeholder mapping, for instance, directs the reader to prepare a map of “no more than 10 to 12 stakeholders in order to make a map clear enough to understand” (p. 102). Here as elsewhere the need to keep analysis simple seems to trump the need to respond adequately to the analytical demands of challenging peacebuilding contexts. Readers are also given advice that feels far too rudimentary (perhaps almost patronising) for grappling with the gravity and complexity of human interaction and suffering at stake: “If they [stakeholders] are in conflict with each other, use a dotted line or a zigzag line. If one stakeholder is exercising influence or controlling another, use an arrow at the end of the line to illustrate the direction of influence” (p. 102-103).

Simple tools can, of course, be incredibly valuable. Indeed, the links between the simple and the complex, and particularly the capacity for simple rules or patterns to generate non-linear, emergent and self-organising effects represents an intriguing possibility for those looking to intervene in complex conflict situations. Peacebuilders have therefore recently begun to engage with burgeoning theories of complexity, chaos and emergence (eg, see Ricigliano 2003; Hendrick 2009; Körppen, Ropers & Gießmann 2011; Coleman 2011) following the rapid rise of these approaches in the natural and life sciences. Unfortunately, Schirch’s engagement with complexity theory is limited to only a very short discussion (p. 22) and a smattering of comments throughout. It is also at least partly misguided, confusing that which is merely complicated (eg, the parts of a computer) with complex systems in which order arises ecologically (p. 22) through the interactions of local agents, as occurs in ant colonies, traffic flows or brains. This sets the stage for her support for rather conventional planning tools such as log frames (p. 7, 192-193) that appear largely incapable of either

grappling with the complex contingency of most peacebuilding situations or tapping into the curious power of complexity phenomena.

This is not to say that the handbook wholly bypasses the challenges and complexities of peacebuilding. Readers are reminded throughout of the limitations of efforts to analyse unfamiliar, complex and conflict-affected settings. The advice that external interveners need to cultivate humility, counter overconfidence (p. 30) and to work in partnership with insiders (p.15-22) is particularly welcome. These recommendations go some way toward complementing – and offering a corrective to – the simple frameworks and tools on offer. But a handbook that provides frameworks that are both familiar and basic risks feeding precisely into the easy intervener confidence and “can-do” attitude that Schirch warns can lead to inadequate analysis and poor results. Readers are given the impression that “results chains” really do work (p. 169) rather than understanding that the frameworks on offer and cause-effect relationships, while useful heuristics, are unlikely to apply or emerge in peacebuilding practice as laid out in this handbook.

No doubt some sort of guiding heuristic is necessary for peacebuilding efforts, but would-be peacebuilders also need to be equipped to deal with the contingency, complexity, messiness and difference they are likely to encounter in the field. This *Conflict Assessment and Peacebuilding Planning* handbook tends to prioritise the first at the expense of the second. Students of peacebuilding will find a range of useful tools for distilling and reflecting upon the key elements of peacebuilding practice in order to better plan, implement and evaluate peacebuilding efforts, but they will also need to look elsewhere to complement and extend upon the offerings of this handbook.

References

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